

R.A.S. SERVICES

THESIS REVISION ACTION PLAN

| PhD Environmental Management | UNISA

Prepared by R.A.S. Services | April 2026

01 · PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

This document sets out the structured plan that R.A.S. Services will follow to address the supervisor's feedback on Chapter 1 of 's PhD thesis. The supervisor identified four core problem areas. Each area is addressed in turn, with a clear diagnosis, the specific actions required, and the expected output.

Document	Thesis Draft — Chapter 1 (Introduction)
Thesis Title	Teachers' Perceptions on the Impact of Elevated Indoor Temperatures on Children in ECD Centres in Hammanskraal, Gauteng
Institution	University of South Africa (UNISA)
Degree	PhD: Environmental Management
Supervisor	Prof K. Semenya
Service Provider	R.A.S. Services
Prepared	April 2026

02 · SUPERVISOR'S FEEDBACK — DIAGNOSIS

The supervisor identified four interconnected problems in the current Chapter 1. Each is summarised below alongside its root cause as identified during our review of the draft.

#	Problem Identified by Supervisor	Root Cause (Our Assessment)
1	Misalignment: introduction does not engage with teacher perceptions, ECD-specific developmental vulnerabilities or pedagogical practices. Grandiose claims.	The opening paragraphs are too general and do not engage with the specific context of the study.
2	Epistemological stance is unclear at PhD level. The study does not state whether it is exploratory, inductive, deductive or a mix.	The study does not clearly state its epistemological stance, which is a requirement for a PhD thesis.
3	Problem statement is too long and narrative. It reads like an extended literature review and lacks sharp problem focus.	The problem statement is too long and narrative, and lacks a sharp problem focus.
4	Research gap is not sharply articulated. The stated gap ('understanding of indoor climate') is too broad and generic.	The research gap is not sharply articulated and is too broad and generic.

03 · DETAILED ACTION PLAN

Issue 1 — Misalignment of Introduction with Study Focus

What the supervisor said:

- The introduction hardly engages with 'teachers' perceptions'.
- There is little emphasis on ECD-specific developmental vulnerability.

- Much of the discussion focuses on schools in general, not ECD centres.
- Environmental design discussion dominates; perceptions, lived experience, and pedagogical impacts are underdeveloped.

What the draft currently does:

The opening of Chapter 1 reads as a broad review of climate change, school buildings, and heatwaves globally. The thesis title foregrounds teacher perceptions and ECD centres, but these themes appear only briefly and late. The first several paragraphs could belong to any environmental science study about schools in general.

Actions required:

- **Reframe the opening paragraph:** Begin Chapter 1 with the specific context: ECD centres in Hammanskraal, teachers as the unit of perception, and thermal stress as the lived daily reality. Remove the generic school-buildings preamble.
- **Foreground 'teacher perceptions' as the conceptual anchor:** Within the first 300 words, establish that this study is primarily about how teachers perceive, interpret, and respond to elevated indoor temperatures — not merely about measured thermal data.
- **Add ECD-specific vulnerability content:** Include a dedicated paragraph on why ECD centres specifically warrant attention: younger children's physiological sensitivity, lower adaptive capacity, greater dependency on adult caregivers, and the policy gap for ECD infrastructure in South Africa.
- **Shift environmental design content to Chapter 2:** Detailed building material and structural discussion belongs in the literature review, not the introduction. Move or remove it from Chapter 1.
- **Align every paragraph back to the title:** After drafting, conduct a paragraph-by-paragraph alignment check: does each paragraph connect to teacher perceptions, ECD centres, or Hammanskraal? If not, relocate it.

Expected output:

A revised introduction (approx. 600–900 words) that opens in Hammanskraal ECD centres, foregrounds teacher perceptions as the primary lens, establishes ECD-specific vulnerability in the opening paragraphs, and reserves general climate and building content for the literature review.

Issue 2 — Epistemological Stance Is Unclear

What the supervisor said:

- At PhD level, the introduction must clearly signal the epistemological stance.
- The supervisor asked: Are you studying measured thermal conditions, or perceptions and experiences, or the interface between physical exposure and pedagogical practice?
- This is currently unclear.

What the draft currently does:

Chapter 1 uses both quantitative temperature measurement references and qualitative perception language interchangeably, without ever declaring the paradigm. Chapter 3 mentions both qualitative and quantitative design but does not connect this back to an epistemological position in the introduction. A PhD examiner cannot determine from Chapter 1 whether this is an interpretivist study, a positivist study, or a mixed-methods study with a defined philosophical position.

Actions required:

- **Decide and declare the epistemological position:** Based on the methodology (qualitative perceptions + quantitative temperature readings), this study sits within a pragmatist or mixed-methods paradigm. This must be explicitly stated in Chapter 1.
- **Add a brief epistemological paragraph:** Insert a paragraph (5–8 sentences) after the research purpose section that states: (a) the ontological stance — what the researcher believes about reality in this context; (b) the epistemological stance — what counts as knowledge in this study; (c) why a mixed-methods approach is appropriate for this research.

- **Align the research questions to the stance:** Review all five research questions. Questions about 'environmental parameters' suggest positivist measurement. Questions about 'opinions of educators' suggest interpretivism. The epistemological statement must explain how both coexist and serve the study's aim.
- **Cross-check with Chapter 3:** Ensure that the justification for the mixed-methods design in Chapter 3 references and reinforces the epistemological position stated in Chapter 1.

Expected output:

A clearly positioned epistemological paragraph within Chapter 1 that specifies the research paradigm, explains how qualitative and quantitative elements complement each other, and removes any ambiguity about what kind of knowledge this study produces.

Issue 3 — Problem Statement Is Too Long and Narrative

What the supervisor said:

- A problem statement should clearly identify the problem, explain why it matters, show what is unknown, and justify why this study is needed.
- Instead, the current section reads like an extended literature review.
- It repeats climate change information and lacks a sharp problem formulation.

What the draft currently does:

The problem statement currently spans approximately 4–5 pages and includes extensive global and South African climate statistics, physiological descriptions of heat stress, and quotations from multiple sources. While this content is valuable, it belongs in the literature review (Chapter 2), not in the problem statement. The result is that the actual problem — the gap in knowledge about teacher perceptions of heat in ECD centres in Hammanskraal — is buried and never stated with precision.

Actions required:

- **Reduce the problem statement to 300–450 words maximum:** A PhD problem statement is focused, not exhaustive. It states the problem in the opening sentence, supports it in 2–3 paragraphs, and ends with the study's justification.
- **Follow the standard four-part structure:** Structure the revised problem statement as follows: (1) State the problem clearly — ECD centres in Hammanskraal experience elevated indoor temperatures, and no study has examined how teachers perceive and respond to these conditions. (2) Explain why it matters — children in ECD centres are physiologically vulnerable; teacher perceptions shape classroom management and protective behaviour. (3) Show what is unknown — the gap in literature (geographical, methodological, institutional). (4) Justify the study — evidence is needed to inform ECD infrastructure policy and teacher support frameworks.
- **Move supporting climate data to Chapter 2:** All extended statistics, global heatwave data, and building materials content currently embedded in the problem statement should be relocated to the appropriate sections of the literature review.
- **End with a clear, single-sentence problem statement:** The last sentence of the problem statement section should articulate the core problem in one precise sentence that can be quoted by an examiner.

Expected output:

A tightly written problem statement of 300–450 words that follows the four-part structure, ends with a single precise problem sentence, and does not repeat content that belongs in the literature review.

Issue 4 — Research Gap Is Not Sharply Articulated

What the supervisor said:

- The stated gap ('A significant gap exists in understanding children's vulnerability') is too vague and lacks specificity.

- The supervisor asked: Is the gap geographical (Hammanskraal)? Methodological (qualitative teacher perceptions)? Institutional (ECD vs. schools)? Policy-related?
- The gap must be explicit and defensible.
- To be defensible at PhD level, the study must clearly claim novelty.

What the draft currently does:

The current gap statement uses broad language about a general lack of understanding of children's vulnerability to heat in learning environments. This is not sufficient at doctoral level because it does not specify what type of gap exists, does not distinguish this study from existing work, and does not make a novelty claim that an examiner can evaluate.

Actions required:

- **Specify the gap across all four dimensions:** The gap statement must address: (a) Geographical gap — no study has examined thermal stress perceptions in ECD centres specifically in Hammanskraal or comparable peri-urban Gauteng settings. (b) Methodological gap — existing studies rely on temperature measurement data; this study introduces qualitative teacher perception data as primary evidence. (c) Institutional gap — literature addresses schools broadly; ECD-specific environments and their unique infrastructure and population vulnerabilities are under-researched. (d) Policy gap — South Africa lacks ECD-specific thermal comfort and infrastructure guidelines.
- **Construct an explicit novelty claim paragraph:** Add a paragraph (after the gap statement) that explicitly states what this study contributes that no prior study has. Example structure: 'This study is among the first to... by... in the context of... contributing to...' The supervisor has provided three suggested novelty framings that should be incorporated.
- **Incorporate the supervisor's suggested novelty framings:** The supervisor specifically suggested: (1) Being one of the first studies to examine teacher perceptions of thermal stress in ECD centres in peri-urban South Africa. (2) Integrating climate change, indoor environmental quality, and early childhood development. (3) Providing context-specific evidence to inform ECD infrastructure guidelines and policy. All three should appear in the novelty claim.
- **Place the gap and novelty claim in the correct position:** The research gap and novelty claim should appear between the problem statement and the research questions — making it clear that the questions arise directly from the identified gap.

Expected output:

A gap statement that specifies the geographical, methodological, institutional, and policy dimensions of the gap, followed by an explicit novelty paragraph that incorporates all three of the supervisor's suggested novelty framings.

04 · RECOMMENDED REVISED STRUCTURE FOR CHAPTER 1

Based on the supervisor's feedback and our review of the draft, the following restructured Chapter 1 outline is recommended. This layout ensures alignment, epistemological clarity, and a defensible gap statement at PhD level.

Section	Heading	Content Focus	Approx. Length
1.1	Introduction	Open in Hammanskraal ECD centres. Establish the lens. State why el	200-300 words
1.2	Background & Context	Brief contextual framing: climate change in Hammanskraal's geographical profile, ECD se	400-500 words
1.3	Epistemological Positioning	Declare the research paradigm. Justify the methodological approach. Explain the ontological	200-300 words
1.4	Problem Statement	Four-part structure: state the problem → what is unknown → justify the stud	300-450 words
1.5	Research Gap & Novelty Claim	Specify the gap (geographical, methodological, institutional, policy). State three novelty claims	250-350 words

Section	Heading	Content Focus	Approx. Length
1.6	Research Questions	Retain existing questions but review alignment to declared epistemological stance. Ensure questions are researchable and measurable.	150–200 words
1.7	Aim and Objectives	Retain with minor edits for alignment to revised epistemological stance.	150–200 words
1.8	Justification / Significance	Condense current justification. Focus on policy-relevant ECD-specific contribution, and South African context.	200–300 words
1.9	Chapter Outline	Retain as is with minor adjustments.	100–150 words

05 · WORK PLAN AND MILESTONES

The revision will be completed in three stages. Each stage has a clear deliverable and a review checkpoint.

Stage	Tasks	Deliverable	Review Point
Stage 1 Diagnosis & Planning	— Full read of Chapter 1 against supervisor feedback — Paragraph-level annotation of what stays, moves, or is rewritten — Produce revised Chapter 1 outline for client approval	Annotated/drafted outline	Client reviews and confirms outline before drafting
Stage 2 Drafting	— Rewrite introduction (Section 1.1) — Add epistemological paragraph (Section 1.3) — Rewrite problem statement (Section 1.4) — Write research gap & novelty claim (Section 1.5) — Adjust remaining sections for alignment	Full revised Chapter 1 draft	Client reviews full revised chapter
Stage 3 Refinement & Delivery	— Address client feedback on final draft — Final alignment check: every paragraph tied to title — Consistency check: terminology, tense, referencing — Final formatting and delivery	Final revised Chapter 1 (clean copy)	Client approves final version for submission to supervisor

06 · WHAT WE NEED FROM THE CLIENT

To carry out this revision effectively, R.A.S. Services requires the following from [redacted] before Stage 2 drafting begins:

Item	Details
Confirmation of epistemological stance	[redacted] must confirm: Is this study primarily interpretivist (perceptions), positivist (measurements), or critical (power relations)?
Preferred novelty framing	Which of the three supervisor-suggested novelty claims is the primary contribution? Rank them in order of importance.
Any additional supervisor comments	If the supervisor provided any verbal or written comments beyond those in the email, please share them here.
Confirmation of Hammanskraal ECD context	Confirm: how many ECD centres are in scope, what is the approximate teacher sample size, and what is the primary focus of the study?
Sign-off on the revised outline	Client must approve the revised Chapter 1 outline (Stage 1 deliverable) before Stage 2 drafting proceeds.

07 · IMPORTANT NOTES

- This plan addresses Chapter 1 revisions only. Chapters 2, 3, and beyond may require separate review once Chapter 1 is accepted by the supervisor.
- The supervisor's feedback email will be retained as a reference document throughout the revision process.

- *All revised content will be returned in the same document format as the original draft unless otherwise requested.*
- *R.A.S. Services provides academic support and structural guidance. The client remains responsible for academic integrity, proper citation, and submission compliance with UNISA's institutional requirements.*
- *File retention policy: all project files are stored for 30 days after final delivery. The client is responsible for backing up all received documents.*